# Stine S. Helmke

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Primary Fields: Development, Behavioral
Secondary Fields: Game Theory

## Education

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| **2021 – present** | **University of Zurich**<br>Ph.D. in Economics (expected: 2027) |
| **2025 – 2026** | **Stanford University**<br>Visiting Student, Department of Economics |
| **2020 – 2021** | **London School of Economics and Political Science**<br>M.Sc. Econometrics and Mathematical Economics with Distinction |
| **2019** | **McGill University**<br>Exchange Student, Desautels Faculty of Management |
| **2017 – 2020** | **University of Amsterdam**<br>B.Sc. Econometrics with First Class Honours |

## References

**Lorenzo Casaburi**
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**Roberto Weber**
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**Arun Chandrasekhar**
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**Marek Pycia**
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## Job Market Paper

**Signaling at a Loss: Experimental Evidence on Conspicuous Consumption in Tanzania**

Individuals in low-income settings invest considerable resources in signals like conspicuous attire. But signaling does not always pay off. The same signal may be beneficial in some domains and disadvantageous in others. Using two experiments in Dar es Salaam, Tanzania, I show that senders signal even when it backfires. In the first experiment, I establish that conspicuous attire enhances professional prestige, leaves credit approval unaffected, and reduces friendship formation and informal help. In the second experiment, senders believe wearing conspicuous attire is beneficial in every domain and give up about 60% of daily per-capita income to dress conspicuously even where it backfires. A structural decomposition attributes at least 74% of what they give up to wrong beliefs, rather than intrinsic motives. Senders appear to hold misperceptions about both which traits the signal conveys and how these traits are valued. Reducing the welfare losses from signaling requires correcting both.

## Work in Progress

**Is Social Learning Gendered?**
with Kobbina Awuah, Rafael Hernández-Pachón, Urša Krenk, Sara Rabino, Daniela Santos Cárdenas, and David Yanagizawa-Drott
*Data collection complete; Funded by Swiss National Science Foundation*

We ask whether individuals learn from others' economic choices and whether gender influences from whom they learn. To answer these questions, we partner with one of the largest microfinance institutions in Kenya, a setting with substantial gender gaps in credit demand. We embed an experiment in the institution's routine loan-application phone call. Applicants are randomly assigned to receive information on the average loan amount requested by a random sample of similar past borrowers. Depending on the treatment arm, this sample consists of male borrowers, female borrowers, or borrowers with no gender specified. We estimate the causal effect of each type of information on applicants' requested loan amounts, as well as on their amounts granted and repaid. Preliminary results show that information about the amounts others requested shifts credit demand. However, conditional on the amount communicated, both women and men respond more strongly to information about peers of their own gender.

**Infidelity and Marital Resource Allocation**
with Sara Rabino
*Piloting*

Infidelity is widespread in Sub-Saharan Africa, especially among men. We study the relationship between infidelity and resource allocation between spouses: when wives expect their husbands to be unfaithful, do they share less of their resources with their husbands, or more? And does the prospect of wives gaining control over resources affect husbands' infidelity? We investigate these questions in three experiments in Dar es Salaam, Tanzania. First, we use a list experiment to measure the prevalence of infidelity in local communities. Second, we run an experiment with wives, where we provide randomized information about local infidelity rates and let them choose how to split a one-year income subsidy between themselves and their husbands. Third, we run an experiment with husbands, where we inform a random sample that their wife may receive an income subsidy of varying size in the future. Six months later, we measure their infidelity through private reports from their wives.

## Other Publications (non-economics)

**Time Course of Optic Nerve Sheath Dilation: In Vitro Response Characteristics to Controlled Pressure Elevations** (with Hans-Christian Hansen and Knut Helmke)
Journal of the Neurological Sciences, 2022, 441, 120358.

## Teaching & Supervision

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| **2023 – 2024** | **University of Zurich** |
| | Introductory Mathematics (Ph.D.) |
| | Advanced Microeconomics 2 (M.A.) |
| | Thesis Supervision in Development Economics (M.A.) |
| **2018 – 2020** | **Fibonacci Studiebegeleiding, Amsterdam** |
| | Multivariable Analysis (B.Sc.) |
| | Linear Algebra (B.Sc.) |
| | Calculus (B.Sc.) |
| **2018 – 2020** | **University of Amsterdam** |
| | Operations Research (B.Sc.) |
| | Calculus (B.Sc.) |

## Grants & Awards

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| 2026 | Swiss Re Fund for Research in Development Economics, University of Zurich *(10,000 CHF – top up, max. amount)* |
| 2026 | GRC Short Grant, University of Zurich *(5,000 CHF, max. amount)* |
| 2026 | Director's Grant, University of Zurich *(10,000 CHF, max. amount)* |
| 2025 | URPP – Equality of Opportunity Research Grant, University of Zurich *(25,000 CHF, max. amount)* |
| 2025 – 2026 | Doc.Mobility, University of Zurich (40,308 CHF) |
| 2024 – present | URPP – Equality of Opportunity, University of Zurich (*Senior Scholarship)* |
| 2023 – 2024 | URPP – Equality of Opportunity, University of Zurich (*Junior Scholarship)* |
| 2023 | GRC Travel Grant, University of Zurich (2,200 CHF) |
| 2023 | Swiss Re Fund for Research in Development Economics, University of Zurich *(7,500 CHF – piloting, max. amount)* |
| 2021 | Studienstiftung des deutschen Volkes, Germany *(10,000 EUR)* |

## Research Experience

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| **2022 – 2023** | **University of Zurich**<br>Research Assistant to Prof. David Yanagizawa-Drott<br>Research Assistant to Prof. Lorenzo Casaburi<br>Research Assistant to Prof. Marek Pycia |
| **2019 – 2022** | **University Medical Center Hamburg-Eppendorf**<br>Research Assistant to Prof. Hans-Christian Hansen |

## Workshops & Conferences

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| 2026 | NEUDC (Cornell), NCBEE (Helsinki), DENS (Basel), ESA (Barcelona), PacDev (Davis), Symposium on the Role of Social Preferences and Social Norms on Economic Life (Zurich) |
| 2025 | URPP Conference on Gender Issues in Education and the Labor Market (Zurich), Advanced Course in Social Norms and Development (Gerzensee) |
| 2024 | Workshop on Social Norms (Zurich), Summer School in Theory-Based Experiments (Caltech) |

## Academic & Community Service

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| 2024 – present | Cohort Representative, Student Life Committee at University of Zurich |
| 2024 | Organizer, Workshop on Social Norms at University of Zurich/ETH |
| 2023 – present | Volunteer, Graduate Applications International Network (GAIN) |
| 2023 – 2024 | Organizational Lead, Third-Year Seminar at University of Zurich |
| 2018 – 2020 | Student Fellow, Program Committee Econometrics at University of Amsterdam |
| 2018 | Chairwoman, International Student Committee Econometrics at University of Amsterdam |

## Miscellany

Software: R, Qualtrics, Stata, Python, LaTeX, Microsoft Office

Languages: German (Native), English (Fluent), French (Fluent)

Citizenship: Germany